

opportunities are available to everyone and rewards are distributed equitably; a genuinely democratic political system in which the preferences of ordinary Americans, not the dictates of big business, determine the course of government policy; an enlightened political culture in which informed citizens actively participate in the public discourse; and a social system in which access to opportunities for education, housing, and employment are not dependent on class, race, or gender.

Good programs and lofty ideals are not enough, however. If they were, the problem of poverty would have been solved a long time ago. We have the know-how, but we lack the political will and the political means necessary to put that knowledge into effect. This point takes us back to the central theme of this book: the connection between poverty and power. Poverty is not so much an intellectual or technical problem as it is a political problem. Policy experts are less crucial to the fight against poverty than are political activists. Poverty endures not because extraordinary ingenuity is required to invent solutions, but because the power to enact needed reforms is lacking. The problem of poverty cannot be effectively remedied without coming to grips with the problem of power—and this means organization, confrontation, and political conflict. As Joe Soss reminds us, only through a willingness to fight for it can a victory against poverty be won.⁹

MOVEMENTS AND POWER

Poverty is a stubbornly persistent condition. We might even be tempted to throw up our hands in the face of this seemingly intractable problem: “That’s just the way things are.” But there is nothing inevitable about millions of Americans living below the poverty line, and the changes needed to reduce poverty, including those cited in the previous section, are within our grasp. We only have to look at the example of other developed nations to see this. Human beings have assembled the structures that perpetuate poverty, and through human intervention these structures can be disassembled, reassembled, or replaced.

It is true, however, that no single person can do much about low-wage work, racial discrimination, inferior schools, residential segregation, inadequate health care, or an unresponsive government. But as the civil rights movement, the women’s movement, and other examples of collective action show, if people band together and take a stand, they can transform the basic norms and institutions of society. They may not have much influence through normal political channels, clogged up by money; they may not have much of a voice in the larger political culture, dominated by a commercialized media system; and they may be lacking in wealth, prestige, connections, and other power resources. But they are not altogether powerless. Ordinary Americans,

including the poor, as Frances Fox Piven argues, have considerable “potential power.” As workers, consumers, tenants, students, welfare recipients, and community residents, we are all enmeshed in a web of cooperative activities, arrangements, and interdependencies whose continued existence depends on our ongoing participation and implicit consent. By withholding our contributions, refusing to play our assigned roles, and strategically violating the rules of the game, we can obstruct the normal workings of social institutions. This “disruptive power,” manifest in civil disobedience, strikes, boycotts, demonstrations, protests, sit-ins, walkouts, and other forms of contentious political behavior, gives otherwise powerless people real leverage. By skillfully exploiting this power to threaten or create disorder, poorer Americans and their allies can conceivably extract concessions from business owners, government officials, and other decision-making authorities and can potentially generate momentum for more far-reaching reforms.¹⁰

Poverty is created and maintained through the exercise of power, and it can be eradicated only through a countervailing or oppositional mobilization of power. This requires an upsurge of “organized people power,” a democratic resurgence played out not just in voting booths, but also in workplaces, public bureaucracies, communities, and the streets. This might seem hopelessly idealistic, but in fact thousands of advocacy groups, community and student activists, labor organizers, progressive intellectuals, and working Americans—based in what Earl Wyson, Robert Perrucci, and David Wright call “alternative power networks”—have been or currently are engaged in battles on many fronts to promote progressive social change.¹¹ Consider just a few examples. The Democratic Socialists of America (DSA) is an activist organization that for many years now has been fighting to create a more democratic, equal, and humane society.¹² Family Values @ Work, Forward Together, and MomsRising, along with other similarly focused organizations, have been at the forefront in battles over pay equity, health care, child care, sick leave, parental leave, and more flexible, family-friendly workplaces.¹³ Founded in 1968, the Center for Community Change is a grassroots activist group committed to the organization and empowerment of low-income people, particularly people of color, around issues of social and economic justice.¹⁴ Immigrant organizations, including the Washington Immigrant Solidarity Network, have helped revitalize the labor movement in Los Angeles and elsewhere, pressing not only for better wages but also for immigration reform and citizenship rights.¹⁵ Activists in the environmental justice movement have exposed the pattern of hazardous waste and pollutants being disproportionately located near poor and minority communities, and they have organized opposition to racist environmental, transportation, and development policies.¹⁶ The Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement was sparked by the killing of Trayvon Martin in Sanford, Florida, in 2012, followed by the acquittal of his killer, George Zimmerman, in 2013, as well as by the

police killing of Michael Brown in Ferguson, Missouri, in 2014. Though police brutality and racism in the criminal justice system are central issues in the BLM agenda, the platform of The Movement for Black Lives affirms a more encompassing vision, calling for, among other things, economic justice, community control, and political self-determination.¹⁷

The fate of poorer Americans is closely tied especially to the state of working-class activism. Though on the defensive since the 1970s, the labor movement, including both unionized and nonunionized workers, is still the most potent expression of “people power” and the only force ultimately capable of challenging the economic, political, and cultural dominance of business.¹⁸ Due to weak labor laws and lax enforcement, along with the determined opposition of employers, union organizing today is a daunting challenge. With little immediate prospect of unionization, many low-wage workers have forged innovative grassroots organizations separate from, though sometimes intersecting with, organized labor.¹⁹ These workers—including “domestic workers, day laborers, restaurant workers, taxi drivers, guestworkers, garment workers, nail salon workers, farmworkers and more”—are often aided in their efforts by “worker centers,” more than two hundred of which have appeared throughout the country since the early 1990s.²⁰ Including the New York Taxi Workers Alliance, the National Domestic Workers Alliance, and the Coalition of Immokalee Workers, worker centers are community-based institutions that, along with other services, advocate on behalf of low-wage workers, provide legal assistance, draw media attention, build local coalitions, and help organize demonstrations and direct action engagements.²¹ One example is the Restaurant Opportunities Centers United (ROC). Through such tactics as the “public shaming” of targeted restaurants, ROC has helped workers in the food industry achieve higher pay and a more humane workplace environment.²²

The Fight for \$15 campaign, which labor expert Ruth Milkman calls “the single most important initiative on the labor front in the last few years,” is one of today’s more visible expressions of “people power.”²³ Fight for \$15 began in 2012 when several hundred fast-food workers in New York City walked off their jobs to protest low wages, bad working conditions, and mistreatment at the hands of managers. Workers at McDonald’s have been among the core activists in this campaign since its inception, but the movement has expanded to include workers in retail establishments, home health-care and child-care industries, airport workers, and others. Through nationwide one-day strikes and sit-ins, with support from religious groups, Black Lives Matter, community organizations, and sympathetic politicians, demonstrators have drawn public attention to the injustice of immensely profitable corporations paying their workers poverty level wages. “This movement is changing our political debate,” says Mary Kay Henry, president of the Service Employees International Union, which has provided financial backing

for the Fight for \$15. “The movement is changing what employers think they can get away with. The movement is making cities and states raise the minimum wage.”²⁴

Out of necessity, unions today, compared to those of the past, serve more directly as vehicles for fighting poverty. With the decline of jobs in the manufacturing sector, union organizing efforts are targeting low-wage service workers, including custodians, hotel and restaurant employees, workers in the health-care industry, and other segments of the working poor. The Justice for Janitors movement, composed largely of Hispanic immigrants, is a case in point, epitomizing today’s “new unionism,” in which unions, especially “poor workers’ unions,” composed disproportionately of women, immigrants, and racial and ethnic minorities, look more like social movements than bureaucratic organizations.²⁵ For proponents of this new unionism, the labor movement is a dynamic force for social change, but only when it taps the collective power of the larger working class and emphasizes not just bread-and-butter union issues, but more fundamental “demands for democracy and equality.”²⁶ This social-movement unionism requires organized labor to establish closer ties between local unions and their communities, including the nonunion population of low-wage workers, the unemployed, welfare recipients, and other disadvantaged groups.²⁷ It also requires the labor movement to reinvent itself by pursuing a partnership or “fusion” with other progressive social movements, including those organized around issues of race, gender, sexuality, the environment, globalization, and peace.²⁸ These coalition-building strategies, besides creating a substantial oppositional power base, hold out the promise of a narrow workplace unionism being transformed into a broader movement for social and economic justice.

A reinvigorated labor movement, with a stronger economic and political presence, can win benefits for the working class and the poor: higher wages, better working conditions, a more generous welfare state, and worker-friendly government policies. Beyond this, however, labor activism is a democratizing force. It opens opportunities for political participation and self-determination on the part of otherwise marginalized people and empowers poorer Americans, enhancing their capacity for collective action and equipping them for future struggles. Today’s labor movement, reconfigured as a genuine social movement, in conjunction with other social justice movements, has the ability to oppose a structure of power that has become dangerously imbalanced. The example of these movements offers up a vision of how poor and working-class Americans can mobilize their potential power to promote social change.

It is sometimes said that poor people should pull themselves up by their own bootstraps. This is good advice. But for such efforts to be successful, they must be collective rather than individual undertakings, political rather than purely personal endeavors. Only a broad-based mobilization of power

can bring about the economic and political changes needed to eradicate poverty. A collective bootstraps strategy, with poorer Americans taking the lead, joined together through labor unions, worker centers, community groups, and grassroots organizations, and with the support of sympathetic political officeholders, is the best hope for a successful war against poverty. While poverty and powerlessness normally go hand in hand, the social justice movements on the scene today testify to the potential power possessed by poorer Americans. Only by more fully realizing this potential is there any chance of achieving the ambitious goal enunciated by Martin Luther King Jr. fifty years ago: “the total, direct and immediate abolition of poverty.”²⁹